PCC vice-chief, wondering where Rahul Gandhi stands. Which, of course, is as subject to contrary pulls, and hence fluctuation, as anything else.

On the surface, he's being even-handed—and certainly not out-and-out anti-Gehlot. Just when many in the Congress expected Rahul to snub Gehlot for hitting out at Pilot in the interview, the Congress leader recently said "both leaders are assets for us". Interpretations abound. "I feel it shows Rahul backs Gehlot," says a party spokesperson. He even suspects that Gehlot launched his broadside with the consent of some of the top brass.

Meanwhile, Priyanka has joined the yatra and Gehlot invited Sonia to join it as well. The Rajasthan Congress's own yatra through the shifting sands of factional politics might be set up for some stormy months ahead—but it will need to survive its internal battles before facing external ones. ■




ANI



**PLEADING INNOCENCE**
KCR's daughter K. Kavitha, responding to the ED notice, alludes to the allegation against B.L. Santhosh (inset)

TELANGANA/ TRS-BJP

# CARTEL COMBAT

**By Amarnath K. Menon**

The battle between the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) and its new national/local rival—the BJP—has been scaled up to another level altogether. Now, big names are in the crosshairs as targets and there could be hell to pay on both sides. K. Kavitha, daughter of TRS supremo and Telangana chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), has been dragged into the Delhi liquor policy scam. After figuring in an Enforcement Directorate (ED) remand report filed for businessman Amit Arora, she is now slated to be questioned by the CBI on December 11. And intriguingly, this drama is unfolding along with a parallel one: the TRS formally raking up the name of BJP national general secretary B.L. Santhosh in connection with an alleged poaching attempt on its party MLAs in the run-up to the recently concluded Munugode assembly bypoll.

How did Kavitha, a member of the legislative council in Telangana, come to figure in the murky story around what's come to be known as 'Liquorgate'—the subject of heated rhetoric in faraway Delhi between the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which rules that state, and the BJP? If the ED is to be believed, KCR's daughter is allegedly a key part of the 'South Group'—along with Sarath Reddy and Magunta Srinivasulu Reddy—that is alleged to have played a role in manipulating Delhi's liquor policy. The group, the ED report claims, paid Rs 100 crore in kickbacks through Arora to businessman Vijay Nair, who allegedly received it on behalf of AAP leaders. Arora, who has been arrested, backed this in his statement, the report claims. The liquor policy, the report adds, promoted the formation of cartels through the back door. Profit margins of 12 per cent (wholesale) and 185 per cent (retail) were allegedly awarded and other illegal activities incentivised as part of the policy. 'The 12 per cent margin to wholesalers was devised to extract half of it as kickback to AAP leaders,' reads the report.

BJP leaders in Telangana are, in fact, now alleging irregularities in the state's own excise policies and demanding a CBI probe, something the state has been fighting. N.V.S.S. Prabhakar, vice-president of the state BJP unit, said at a press conference that those named in the Delhi liquor scam were responsible for the policy changes in Telangana too.

This is the first time Kavitha's name has figured formally in the Delhi liquor scam investigation. The report alleges she changed her mobile devices for the number 6209999999